I Am My Own Wife

By Doug Wright

NOTE: Actor should speak in broken English with a German accent. She is, in fact, a man, roughly sixty-five years old.

CHARLOTTE: **(Pg 15)** Come in, please. There is room for everyone, yes? *(gestures expansively to her belongings)* **(Pg 14)** ***Wilkommen in meinem Grunderzeit Museum.*** Welcome to my Grunderzeit Museum. People always come to see my collection. Everything is from the period in Germany between 1890 and 1900. "The Gay Nineties." *(Gestures to an ornate door)* **(Pg 15)** This old door is not original, ***nein***. I saved it from a house on Prenzlauer Street. Before the Russians blew up the houses, I took such things. . . a cupboard . . . an old sideboard . . . this clock. *(she cradles it in her arms like a baby)* **(Pg 16)** I had a feeling for such things. And so I saved [them]. **(Pg 18)** When families died, I ***became*** this furniture *(gestures to the collection)* When the Jews were deported in the Second World War, I ***became*** it. When citizens were burned out of their homes by the Communists, I ***became*** it.

INTRODUCTION

Lothar Berfelde, better known as Charlotte von Mahlsdorf, was a transvestite and celebrated antiques dealer who successfully navigated the two most oppressive regimes of the past century- the Nazis and the Communists. While openly gay and defiantly in drag, von Mahlsdorf was both hailed as a cultural hero and accused of colluding with the Stasi secret police of East Berlin.

This is her story . . . based on actual interview

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CHARLOTTE: **(Pg 14)** Some people, they come to see me. ***Ich bin Transvestit.*** **(Pg 14)** But soon they look at the furniture *(taking inventory of her collection)* Lamps and vases, records, matchboxes, pictures and of course [my] gramophone.

(She picks it up, blows the dust off of it and prepares to play a record while she speaks) **(Pg 46)** Even when I was a little child, no one wanted phonographs. They all wanted radios. But what did I want with a radio? To hear Hitler babble? No, thank you! *(She pauses with a record in her hands)* **(Pg 17)** At one time I had many such records – Mendelssohn and Offenbach. But during the time of Hilter it was very dangerous to possess music from Jewish composers. And so I thought, I must save these records. And so I glued false labels onto the records, for safety. *(She places the record and the gramophone)* And when the war was over, I took a sponge and with water I took the labels back off. *(As the music plays, she hums and sways with the music)* **(Pg 11)** In the Second World War, when the airplanes flew over Mahlsdorf, and the bombs were coming down, I played British and American records. I thought, *(she chuckles)* if they hear me, they will know I'm their friend. *(beat)* **(Pg 46)** These machines gave me so much pleasure in my childhood. If I hadn't had them, I'm not sure I would've survived. Things wer so ghastly with my father – everything my mother and I went through.

(Pg 29) . . . My father was a Nazi. And he was brutal. *(Beat)* **(Pg 31-32)** One evening I asked him, "aren't you ashamed of the way you've treated my mother? And he said:

FATHER: I'll shoot you down like a dog and then I'll shoot your mother and your sister and your brother.

CHARLOTTE: I knew that my father would do this. He locked me in bedroom, but even then I had in my pocket . . . keys. *(She opens the door and creeps out)* My father was lying on the sofa, his gun on the chair next to him. And in that moment, the clock *(she strides to a table and picks a clock up angrily and holds it aloft)* a Westminster clock was chiming. My father's hand was reaching for his weapon. *(She brings the clock down on her father's head, speaking with*

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sudden ferocity) ***Eins! Zwei! Drei! Vier! Funf!*** *(A pause; she dissociates for a moment, becoming oddly contemplative)* Hmm. Yes. *(she smiles and puts the clock back on the table)* We were finally free from the monster. *(beat)*

It was luck for us that in 1943 in Berlin, the government decreed the evacuation of mothers with children because of the air raids. And so my mother took [me] to East Prussia, to the house of my aunt. **(Pg 21-22)** Since she was fifteen years old she never wore ladies' cloths. No. Only boots and jodhpurs. The clothes of a land inspector and not a fine lady. *(She whispers)* I found in her closet . . . Girl's cloths And . . . I . . . put . . . them. . . on. *(She steps before an imaginary mirror, delighted by her image in the glass. She twirls, raising her skirt when she notices her aunt)* My aunt looked at us in the mirror ….

TANTE LUISE: [Well] nature has dared to play a joke on us. You should've been born a girl, and I should've been a man!

CHARLOTTE: In each person, there is a delicate balance of male and female. Just as we can't find two matching leaves from the same tree, it is scientifically impossible to find two human beings whose male and female characteristics match in kind and number.

(Pg 25) The last days of the war were the most dangerous time for me, because I refused to carry a weapon or to wear a uniform. Instead, I had my hair long and blond and my mother's coat, and the shoes of a girl. And so I was – in Germany we say "***Freiwild***." Like the Jews, we were wild game. *(Long beat as Charlotte remembers)*

(Pg 26) I could hear the bombs. *(looks skyward)* There was an air-raid shelter and so I went inside. **(Pg 26-27)** Suddenly the door opened and in came four SS officers. ***Die Kettenhunde*** **(translates to "the chain dogs")*

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SS OFFICER: All deserters shall be shot.

CHARLOTTE: I looked down – I didn't want to see them shoot. I thought, I'll wait until I feel it. But when I looked to the ground I saw the boots of a commander.

SS COMMANDER: Are you a boy or a girl?

CHARLOTTE: And I thought, if they shoot me, what's the difference between a boy and a girl, because dead is dead! *(She become a child and answers)* I am a boy.

SS COMMANDER: How old are you?

CHARLOTTE: Sixteen . . . *(in her adult voice)* And he turned around to face the execution squad commander.

SS COMMANDER: *(With some measure of self-contempt)* We are not so far gone that we have to shoot schoolchildren.

CHARLOTTE: And this was my salvation. *(Beat)*

TRANSITION

But salvation was short lived for Charlotte von Mahlsdorf. The final weeks of April 1945 saw Soviet troops advance on Berlin, bringing World War II in Europe to an end. And the Soviet occupation of East Berlin brough a host of new challenges. Germany had been too busy fighting a war to focus too much on the gay community, unless you were a Jew, of course; but Russia was determined to stamp out all homosexuals.

CHARLOTTE: **(Pg 34)** It was true! The Allies were coming to Berlin. And I saw on the street the large Russian tanks. **(Pg 38)** And then came the wall. For us here in Eastern Berlin it was finished, gay life. No place to meet . . . bars closed . . . advertisements in the newspaper, cancelled. We were not supposed to exist. *(Beat)* So I thought to give homosexual women and men community in this house. *(Motions for the audience to follow her)* **(Pg 36)** Today I show you ***das Geheimnis*** – the secret – of ***meinem Grunderzeit Museum***. *(She unlocks a door, enters and gestures expansively)* **(Pg 37)**

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Welcome to die Mulack-Ritze. And old tavern from the yesterday. It was a restaurant for gays and lesbians. *(lovingly wipes down a table)* This table is over one hundred years old. At this very table ***haben*** Bertolt Brecht and Marlene Dietrich *(mischievously)* [In East Berlin] ***Tanzen ist verboten***. Dancing is forbidden. At least according to the police. **(Pg 69-70)** We played Donna Summer and everyone was dancing and singing under paper lanterns. *(She sways to remembered music, but the memory turns ugly)* And I heard a window smash in my basement. A rock. The Brown plague had come back again. ***Kristallnacht*** once more. The neo-Nazis knew I was a homosexual. They came over the wall – thirty of them – with flare guns and gas pistols. The gays were all cowards, running inside, but the lesbians stayed to fight. *(Long beat)* And my friend Sylvia, she was in the cellar, trying to shut the door, and she got a gas pistol in the eye. A young girl from Frankfurt almost died. They cracked open her cranium with an iron stick. And I was coming from the cellar with an old pickax, and a skinhead met me on the stair. He had a swastika tattooed on his arm, yes?

NEO-NAZI 1: Hitler forgot to shove you in an oven!

CHARLOTTE: And I swung and hit the blade in the old banister, splitting it open like a sapling, ja? And from behind me another voice.

NEO-NAZI 2: We should drown you in the Ostsee!

CHARLOTTE: And then ***die Polizei*** came. And the young men scattered. Like ***die Asche***, after a fire. No one was arrested. No one went to jail.

(Pg 43-44) *(Charlotte's demeanor changes; she speaks cautiously)* One day [the Stasi] came and he wanted me to write exactly what he said: *(She picks up a paper from a side table)* I, Lothar Berfelde, commit myself willingly and freely to working together with the Ministry for State Security. I will report all information which may have the character of an

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action inimical to the state. I will be known by the code name Park. *(quietly)* I signed it. . . and I said to myself, *(defiantly* "I'll still do whatever I want." Meine Tante Luise always said, "Be as smart as the snakes; it's in the Bible . . . never forget that you are living in the lion's den. Sometimes, you must howl with the wolves."

(Pg 69) [Because of me] Home[s] [were] broken into and the Stasi impounded everything. Just like the Nazis during the deportation of Jewish people, they took all things.

(She returns to her furniture for comfort) **(Pg 77)** Nicks and cuts, Stains. Cracks. People sat on it, slept on it, wrote letters on it, ate from it. People tried to burn it. In Nazi times, In Stasi times. And still, it is standing. It is a record, yes? Of living . . . . Of lives. **(Pg 14)** ***Wilkommen in meinem Grunderzeit Museum.*** Welcome to my Grunderzeit Museum

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier

More information about Lothar Berfelde, better known as Charlotte von Mahlsdorf can be found her http://www.glbtqarchive.com/arts/mahlsdorf_c_A.pdf